Marvellous metaphors
Student worksheets

Task 1 – As brave as a lion



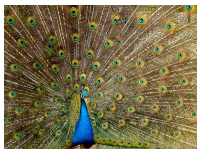
When we want to compare two things that are alike in some way, we sometimes use 'as … as …'. For example, sometimes we compare people with animals:

She's as brave as a lion.

We call these expressions **similes** to show that two different things can have similarities.

a. *With a partner, read the sentences and choose a phrase from the box to complete the simile.*

1. She is always working, in fact she's as busy as a bee
2. He may look thin, but he's as strong as an ox
3. When my Grandpa climbs the stairs, he's as slow as a tortoise
4. My teacher knows a lot, in fact she's as wise as an owl
5. When he showed me his new car, he looked as proud as a peacock
6. I tried to get her to change her mind, but she was as stubborn as a mule


a peacock


a mule


a bee


an owl


an ox


a tortoise

b. *Now ask your partner if they know anyone who matches the similes above and why.*

Example: 'Do you know anyone who is as brave as a lion?'
'Yes, my sister is as brave as a lion, because she rides a bike in London.'

c. *See if you can think up two new similes using animals from your country.*

b.

1. My sister is as busy as a bee because she works and studies all day.
2. My uncle is as strong as an ox because he can lift heavy boxes.
3. My grandfather is as slow as a tortoise when he climbs the stairs.
4. My teacher is as wise as an owl because she always gives good advice.
5. My cousin looked as proud as a peacock when he showed me his new car.
6. My brother is as stubborn as a mule because he never changes his mind.

c.

1. My sister is as loyal as a dog.
2. My brother is as hardworking as an ant.

Task 2 – Finding metaphors

A **metaphor** is like a **simile** in that it compares and links two different ideas or things. However, with a **metaphor** there is no 'as … as' or 'like' before it.

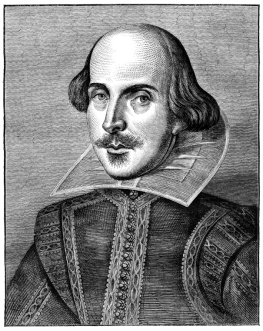
a. *Read the text below and underline six metaphors that are connected to roads, travel or transport. The first one is done for you.*

Mrs Smith has really got problems with her children. Her oldest son Jake is at a crossroads. He was in a dead-end job so he gave it up. Now he can't find another one and he doesn't know which way to turn. His relationship with his girlfriend is over. They have had a bumpy ride so they have decided to separate. Meanwhile the younger son, Cyril, has gone off the rails. He has stopped going to school. 'It's very worrying,' said Mrs Smith. 'I want both my sons to get back on track as soon as possible.'

Task 2 – Finding metaphors continued

b. *Work with a partner and match the six metaphors in the text to the definitions below.*

1. ended up in a chaotic state = gone off the rails
2. something which has no future = a dead-end job
3. a difficult time = a bumpy ride
4. a point where a decision must be made = at a crossroads
5. to start working normally again = get back on track
6. what to do next = which way to turn



Task 3 – Discussing metaphors

Shakespeare used a lot of metaphors to express his feelings about life. In Sonnet 73*, he describes himself as an old man and compares himself to a time of year (a.) and then a time of day (b.). Read a. and b. in small groups.*

a.
That time of year thou mayst in me behold
When yellow leaves, or none, or few, do hang
Upon these boughs which shake against the cold

b.
In me thou seest the twilight of such day
As after sunset fadeth in the west
Which by and by black night doth take away

Glossary
thou mayst – you might
behold – see/notice
boughs – branches
thou seest – you see
fadeth - fades
doth take - takes

1. *Which time of year does a. refer to?* Late autumn.
2. *Which time of day does b. refer to?* Twilight after sunset.
3. *Decide which extract describes an old man best and why.*
   Extract a is best because the few yellow leaves and cold branches suggest ageing and life's end.

Task 4 – Writing metaphors

Below are three more of Shakespeare's metaphors and what they represent. Working in groups, can you invent another metaphor for each meaning?

	Shakespeare's metaphor	*Meaning*
1.	a 'well-tuned' instrument (from *Othello*)	a happy couple
2.	'pearls from diamonds dropped' (from *King Lear*)	tears
3.	an 'undiscovered country' (from *Hamlet*)	death

1. a happy couple: Their love was a song in perfect harmony.

2. tears: Her tears were silver rivers running down her cheeks.

3. death: Death was a distant shore beyond the sea of life.